

LIFECYCLE OF A BUTTERFLY

Butterflies and moths change from caterpillars to adults in a process called metamorphosis. Their life stages vary according to species. Some caterpillars change inside a silk cocoon rather than the hard case shown here.

1 EGG
A butterfly begins life as an egg the size of a pin head. Butterfly eggs may be laid singly or in clusters.

4 ADULT BUTTERFLY
A colourful butterfly emerges out of the chrysalis. In turn, it will lay its own eggs.

2 CATERPILLAR
A caterpillar hatches from the egg. It eats and eats and sheds its skin (moult) several times as its body gets bigger.

3 CHRYSALIS
The final moult reveals a hard case, or chrysalis, inside which the caterpillar stays as its body changes.

LARGEST AND SMALLEST

The female Queen Alexandra's Birdwing is the world's biggest butterfly with a wingspan of up to 28 cm (11 in). The Western Pygmy Blue has a wingspan of less than 2 cm (0.5 in), making it one of the world's smallest.



CATERPILLAR MOVEMENT

Caterpillars have three pairs of legs at the front and between two and five pairs of false legs, which provide grip, at the hind end. They move with a wave-like motion.

1 FRONT MOVES
The caterpillar moves its front part forwards, leaving the rear anchored.

2 REAR CATCHES UP
It draws its hind end forwards while holding on with the front legs.

3 FRONT MOVES AGAIN
It then moves its front again, gripping with the false legs at the back.

CATERPILLARS

Different species of caterpillars vary greatly in appearance, but all are big eaters. Most feed on plants, often of one type only. Less usual foods include wool and the horns of dead cattle.

